A knowledge economy like India putting such a premium on human resources makes it imperative, for itself as much as for the world, to focus on realizing SDG targets by 2030. It is clear from the national campaigns initiated after 2014 that these 17 SDG defined by the UN are indeed among the government's key objectives. And this has continued despite the Covid challenge. Take the Jan Dhan–Aadhaar–Mobile (JAM) trinity that has empowered millions of vulnerable by providing banking and digital services. In a similar way, the expanding health coverage demonstrates that this need not just be the prerogative of the developed. The Beti Bachao Beti Padhao scheme for girls' education also has such sweeping societal implications, and so does the Jal Jeevan Mission to bring tap water to homes, the Digital India network to bring masses online and the Ujjwala programme to replace burning firewood with cooking gas. These are examples of the ability to address long-standing challenges in a lasting manner. The aggregate impact of these campaigns is improving the socio-economic welfare of a significant proportion of humanity. Why India matters is because its record of progress would determine global success in meeting the SDG Agenda 2030.

Not all readily appreciate that it is India's political choices that have enabled democratic values to achieve a near universal status. Till we took the call, these practices were widely perceived as the prerogative of developed countries only. It, of course, was enabled by the fact that democratic traditions are deeply rooted in Indian history and culture. But this aspect was not asserted even by India in earlier years, and its modern incarnation was depicted for years as an anomaly. So much so that opinions in the West were quite comfortable recommending military rule as a better governance solution for the 'less worthy'. Our own region provided the most telling examples in that regard, with Pakistan touted for years as a preferred partner. In fact, India made a difference not just by building a modern democratic polity under testing economic conditions but by drawing on its own heritage of pluralism to do so. Unlike many other societies, India never put a premium on uniformity. On the contrary, its innate unity, which was expressed through diversity, is the real basis of its culture of confabulation.

In contrast to challenges faced by others in recent years, India's credentials have only become stronger with time. Whether it is in terms of electoral participation or broadening of political representation, the